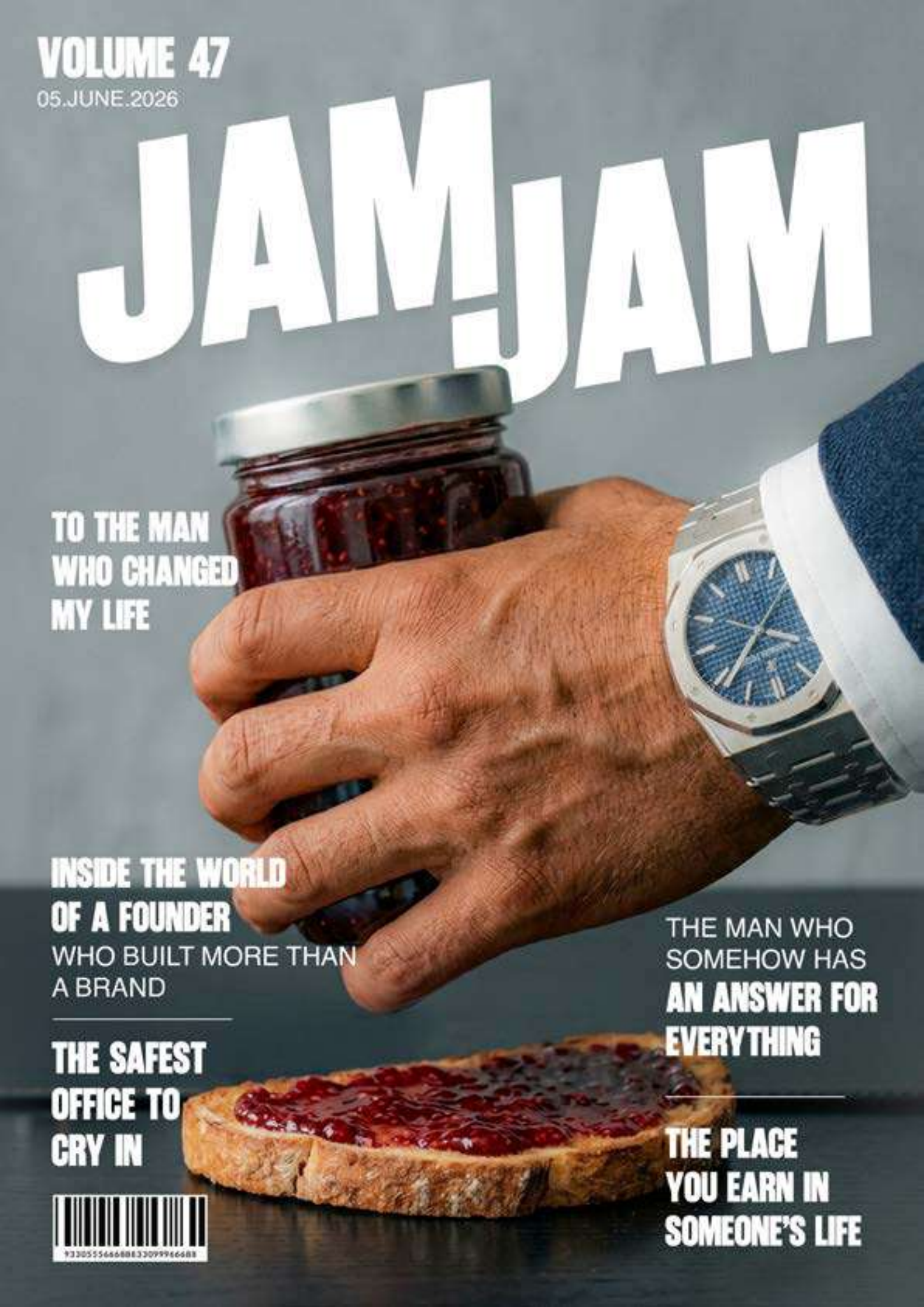
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TO THE MAN WHO CHANGED MY LIFE

INSIDE THE WORLD OF A FOUNDER
WHO BUILT MORE THAN A BRAND

THE SAFEST OFFICE TO CRY IN

THE MAN WHO SOMEHOW HAS
AN ANSWER FOR EVERYTHING

THE PLACE YOU EARN IN SOMEONE'S LIFE

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“The real impact of a person
is usually found in who people
became after knowing them.”

LETTER FROM THE EDITORS

This is your reminder.

A reminder that you are deeply loved, appreciated
and never taken for granted.
That your presence in people's lives has meant
more than you probably realise.
That people carried your words with them.
Your encouragement. Your chaos.
Your (sometimes terrible) humour.
Your advice. Your belief in them.
Even the smallest moments you probably forgot about years ago.
These pages are filled with stories from people who love you in all the different ways a person can be loved - as a brother, a friend, a mentor, a founder, a safe place, a source of strength or simply someone who made life feel lighter and bigger at the same time.

And maybe **the most beautiful thing about a life is how much of it continues in other people.**

- Your HQ Family



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EVERYTHING HE BECAME WAS
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A PARENT'S LOVE DOESN'T NEED TO BE
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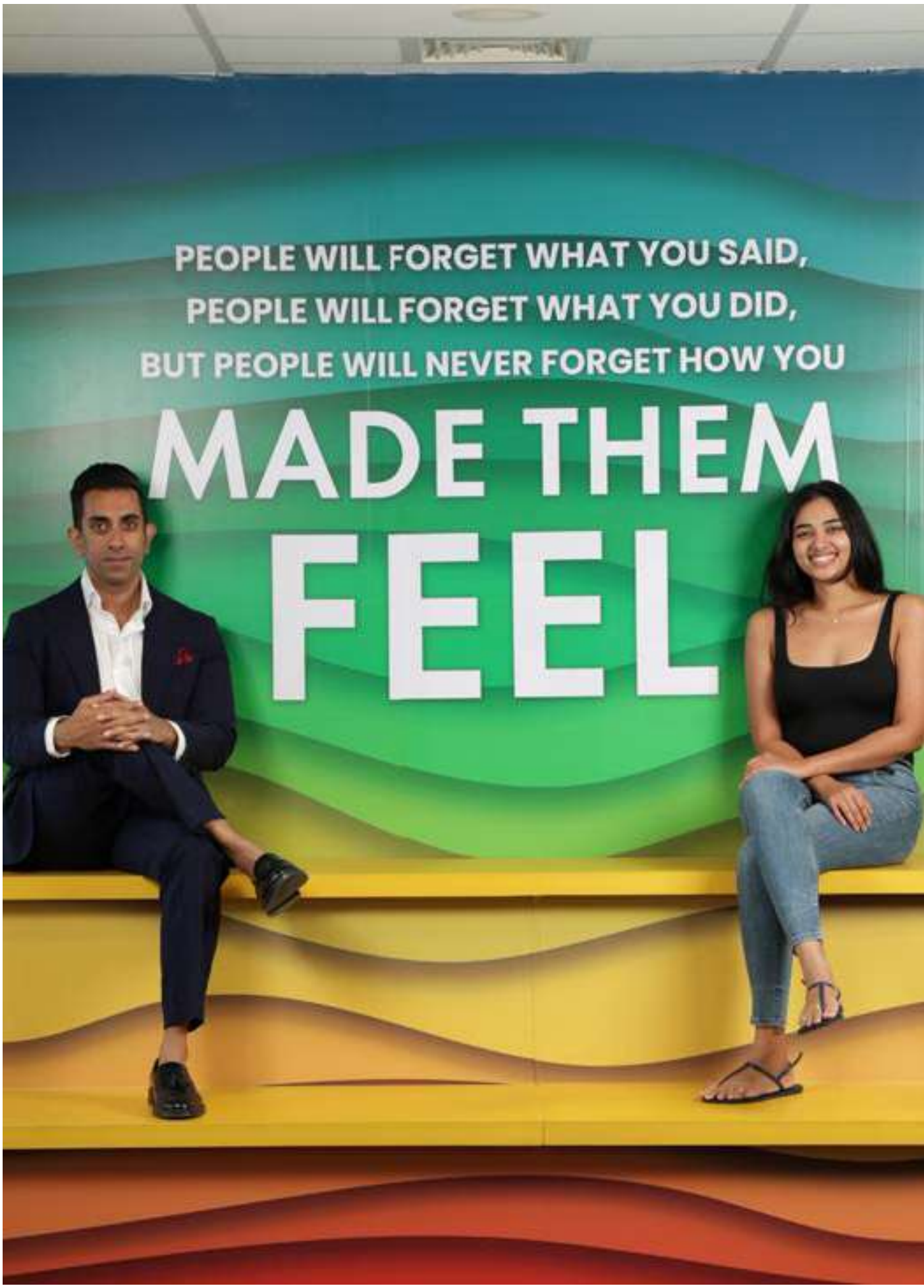


IN REAL TIME

From the people still in the middle of it all. The people witnessing the ideas, the chaos, the laughter and the magic of who you are while it's all still happening.






PEOPLE WILL FORGET WHAT YOU SAID,
PEOPLE WILL FORGET WHAT YOU DID,
BUT PEOPLE WILL NEVER FORGET HOW YOU
MADE THEM
FEEL

Inside The World of A Founder Who Built More Than A Brand

"

THERE ARE PEOPLE WHO BUILD BRANDS.

AND THEN THERE ARE PEOPLE WHO BUILD WORLDS AROUND THEM.

At first glance, Shalin looks exactly like the kind of person you would expect to have an intimidating amount of ego. The aesthetic is all there - the beautifully curated spaces, the impeccable attention to detail, the effortless understanding of luxury and experience. When I first walked into the Parkland building over five years ago, armed with nothing more than my assumptions and his Instagram profile, I thought I had him figured out almost immediately.

Very "look at me, I'm fancy."

What I didn't realise then was that the polish was real — but the ego wasn't.

Because behind the beautifully constructed image is someone surprisingly human. Someone deeply caring. Someone who, despite everything he has built, still fundamentally thinks about people first.

I remember being genuinely unreactive the first time I met him. Unlike most people in the company, I was never interviewed by Shalin himself, so when he casually walked into the Luvesence room one day, I had no dramatic first impression. No intimidating corporate moment. No grand introduction.

Over time though, I started noticing something else entirely.

The first clues came through the way people spoke about him when he wasn't around.

I still remember sitting at lunch with Gihan while he spoke about Shalin with a level of loyalty that honestly fascinated me. Not corporate loyalty. Not performative respect. Real loyalty. The kind people carry long after titles stop mattering.
He told me stories about how Shalin lent him his car for his wedding. Another story about taking him to an incredibly fancy restaurant and quietly eating with his hands too to make sure he was comfortable because he didn't know how to use the cutlery..

It sounds insignificant until you realise that this is exactly who he is.

Shalin has an instinctive ability to remove discomfort from a room. To dissolve hierarchy without announcing that he's doing it. He understands something most people in leadership positions never fully grasp - people rarely remember exactly what you said, but they remember how safe you made them feel.

And somehow, despite running a brand built on luxury, aesthetics and precision, he has never made people feel small.

That is probably why people stay.

And why people who have left still speak about him with the same affection years later.

There's also a very specific energy shift that happens when he enters a room. You feel it immediately.
Conversations sharpen. People suddenly become more alert.



The dynamic changes without him even trying. But what makes it unusual is that five minutes later he'll probably be making fun of someone, cracking an outrageously inappropriate joke in the middle of a stressful situation or asking for coffee for the fifth time that day.

That balance is rare.

He can walk into a room with immense presence and dismantle the tension in it seconds later with humour.

I think one of the most defining things about him is that no matter how polished the final outcome looks, he has never behaved as though he is above the work itself.

I saw this most clearly during NOPEX in London. While everyone was rushing around during setup, Shalin was physically on the ground helping fix tables himself. No performance. No "boss watching from afar" energy. Just doing whatever needed to be done to make the experience perfect.

And perfection matters to him. Painfully so.



His attention to detail is honestly terrifying at times. A slightly misplaced product. Lighting that feels off by half a shade. A sentence in content that emotionally lands incorrectly. He notices everything.

But what makes him different is that the obsession with detail never comes from vanity. It comes from emotion.

One question he constantly asks is:
"But what will people feel after seeing this?"

Not think.
Feel.

And I think that explains Spa Ceylon more than any branding document ever could.

For Shalin, this brand has never just been products or stores or campaigns. It is artistry, obsession, storytelling, responsibility and emotion all existing at the same time. You can see it in the way he walks through spaces. The way he rearranges displays himself. The way he fixates on sensory details most people would miss entirely.

Ironically, some of the moments that define him best are not the glamorous ones at all.

They're the moments at 4 a.m. when teams are exhausted during campaigns or setups, and he shows up carrying coffee or Red Bull just to make sure nobody feels like they're struggling alone.

That is the part people outside the company don't see.

The care.

And perhaps that is why people work the way they do for him. It's never been entirely about salaries, titles or corporate ambition. Somewhere along the way, his dream quietly became everyone else's too. Not because he demanded loyalty, but because he earned it.

One of the biggest things I've personally learned from him is kindness. Not performative kindness. Not transactional kindness. Just the simple idea that you lose absolutely nothing by treating people well, even when they may not deserve it.

I've watched him practice that consistently for years.
And I think that's ultimately what people carry with them long after meetings, campaigns and deadlines are forgotten.
Not the stores.
Not the launches.



Not even the brand itself.

But the feeling of being looked after.

In fact, if Spa Ceylon disappeared tomorrow, I genuinely believe his first concern would not be himself. It would be his people. He has openly said that one of his greatest fears is making sure the brands continue to work because he feels responsible for the lives tied to them.

That tells you everything you really need to know about him.

Because long before he built this successful brand (thu thu thu), he built something far rarer:

A place where people felt they mattered.

Shanela Anthony



The Man Who Somehow Has an Answer for Everything

There are certain people you come across in life who make you realise that the world is much bigger than the one you've been living in. For me, one of those people was Shalin Balasuriya.

Long before I ever worked with him, I was watching him. Not in a creepy way. More in the way a confused young person watches people who seem to have figured things out. It started with old interviews. Danu on fire at Kaema Sutra, SimpleBooks and random videos scattered across the internet. What fascinated me wasn't Spa Ceylon or the business success. It was trying to understand what was going on inside that brain. The way he thought about people, brands, and the world challenged how I viewed things. At the time, I couldn't explain why I found it so interesting. Today, I can. Some people give answers. Some people teach you how to think. Shalin was always the latter.

Years later, life somehow decided that I would end up working with him. My first few months involved being called every name except my actual one. Isuru. Rusiru. A few others that I am still convinced were invented on the spot. Somewhere between the wrong names, dad jokes, and daily chaos, a closer bond was formed.



For someone who has built a globally recognised wellness brand, Shalin is remarkably human. He'll discuss global business strategy one moment and make fun of PK the next.

He'll share life-changing advice and follow it up with a joke that probably shouldn't have been said.

What impressed me most was his consistency. If Shalin says something will happen, it usually does. And if it doesn't, he finds another way. More like if someone points a gun at most people, they spend their time worrying about the gun. Shalin is already busy figuring out 146 different ways to get behind it
(he gets the reference).

He's the co-founder of a multimillion-dollar global brand, yet he's still willing to get his hands dirty and work alongside the team. No ego. Just work. And solutions.

I've also seen how much people around him care for him. Family, friends, colleagues, business partners, and employees. Shalin has a rare ability to make people feel seen. He remembers tiny details, checks in, and somehow makes time to be present when most people at his level become less available.

He's also one of the few leaders I've met who genuinely prioritises the growth of the people around him. Not just within the company, but as individuals. He cares less about whether your future serves the organisation and more about whether it serves you.

Then there is the side of Shalin that never makes it into business magazines. The unexpected wingman on a random night out. The person who calls out your nonsense immediately, but somehow ends the conversation with reassurance, a laugh, and usually a hug.

Over the years, I've learnt a lot from Shalin. Probably not as much as I should have. But enough to know that I am a better version of myself than the person who first watched those interviews years ago.

When people talk about Shalin Balasuriya, they often talk about the founder, the entrepreneur, the wellness expert, or the visionary behind Spa Ceylon.

All of those things are true.

But for me, it is much simpler.

He's a genuinely good human being.

And if Spa Ceylon disappeared tomorrow, I have absolutely no doubt what would happen next. Shalin would probably rub some De-Stress Balm on his temples, take a deep breath, and start building the next great thing without breaking a sweat.

So as he celebrates another year of life, I don't wish him greater success. Instead, I wish him what he has spent his life helping others find: wellness, good living, good health, and the strength to continue doing what he does best.

Because there are many successful people in the world. There are far fewer people who leave the people around them better than they found them.

And Shalin Balasuriya happens to be one of them.

Pasindu Wijesuriya



Quiet Turning Points

Dear future me,
Maybe you'll be leading a team. Maybe you'll be building something of your own. Maybe you're somewhere I can't even imagine yet. Even if things are bigger, louder, and maybe even a little more complicated, remember that one of your beginnings was very simple.

Remember when you were quietly wondering if there was more you could try. You didn't have the perfect words for it yet. You just knew you were curious. You wanted to understand the wider world of marketing that Spa Ceylon had to offer and all the ideas that seemed to move so quickly around you and you didn't know where you fit yet.
And before anything changed, remember that you spoke to Shan. the person who changed your entire life.
Which led to a pickleball match.

It's funny, because turning points never look like turning points when they happen. This came after a match, when Shalin asked what you had done before. You answered, probably not as confidently as you hoped. Following with, "Come speak to me at the office."

You walked into "Seven Minutes with Shalin" feeling like you had to explain your whole life properly in a few minutes. Everything you had done, everything you wanted to try, everything you were unsure about. You were trying to sound clear, even though you were still figuring it out as you spoke.

But he listened.

Not in the way people listen just to reply. He listened like he was connecting small pieces you hadn't fully connected yourself yet.

And after hearing everything, he said you should join the ads team.

Andd at the time, maybe you didn't fully know if it was the right decision. Maybe you were just grateful that someone had given you a direction. But now you already know something:
He was right.

You love what you're doing. You get to learn from Shanela, who somehow makes even the most difficult things feel possible. You get to be part of a team that pushes you, teaches you, and lets you see marketing from a completely new side. And you get to work closer with Shalin, you get to watch how quickly his mind moves, how ideas come to him, how creativity is not just something he talks about, but something he lives in the smallest details.
So dear future me, if one day someone asks you how you found your path, don't only talk about the big things.



"

Remember the smaller beginning.
Remember the conversation with Shanela.

Remember the pickleball match.
Remember the seven minutes.
Remember walking into that room nervous.

Remember trying to explain yourself.
Remember that he was right.

And most of all, remember this:
There was a time when you didn't fully believe in yourself yet.
And there was someone who still gave you a place to begin.

Iyadh Ahmed

My Name is Dilshara

Hi Shalin

Just wanted to take a moment to say how grateful I am to be part of HQ and to thank you for creating such an amazing place for all of us.

Over the past three years, HQ has been much more than just a workplace for me. It has honestly felt like a university where I've learned so much, both professionally and personally. The opportunities, experiences, and lessons I've gained here have helped me grow in ways I never expected, and I'm truly thankful for that.
You're genuinely one of the coolest bosses I've ever had, and the culture you've built is a big reason why so many of us enjoy being here. It's rare to find a workplace that inspires people to learn, grow and push themselves every day.

That being said, I do have one small complaint... after more than three years, you still don't know me by my name! Hopefully, this message finally fixes that.

Wishing you a very Happy Birthday and an incredible year ahead filled with happiness, success, good health and everything you deserve. Thank you for everything you do for us.

Dilshara

#BalaBokke



Hi Shalin,

Another year older, another year wiser and another year of pretending age is just a number.

The first time I actually saw "THE SHALIN BALASURIYA" was at CFW in 2023 and who ever thought I'll be working for him now. I'm shocked myself and I'm absolutely grateful I get to work closely with you, learn from you and also proudly be part of the legendary #Balabokke pickleball era. Still waiting for our official team merch though.

But yeah, jokes aside, thank you for being such a cool boss, a great mentor and someone who makes work feel a lot less boring.

Hope you have the best birthday, lots of good food, good vibes and many more adventures around the world. Keep being the inspiring person you are and I hope you get to buy a Porsche someday so that I could get a free ride too.

PS: Special shoutout to your Onitsuka Tigers from Japan. They have been noticed.

Neluka



The 5PM Phone Call

To be honest, I still remember the day I got hired.
I was working at Bata at the time when I got a call from Shalin's personal assistant PK; around 5 p.m., asking if I could attend an interview at 6. Realistically, I knew I couldn't make it. I had already left work and was far away. But for some reason, I immediately said yes.

I still remember turning my bike around and rushing to one of my friend's salons in Rathmalana just to somehow make that interview happen. I ended up doing the interview from the reception area of the salon, trying to make everything work with whatever I had at that moment. Looking back now, it feels almost cinematic in a funny way. But I think that moment quietly changed my entire life.

Because if I had missed that call or not taken that interview, I genuinely think my life would have gone in a completely different direction.

Joining Spa Ceylon Marketing HQ did not just give me a job. It gave me a second home.
One thing I always admired about Shalin is how deeply he notices people. Not just work. People.
Their creativity, their strengths, the tiny things they don't even notice about themselves yet. There were moments where he be-

lieved in my abilities more than I did. And because of that, I got opportunities that completely changed my life; even the chance to visit another country, something younger me would have never imagined.

But beyond all the achievements and work, what stayed with me most is the human side of him.

Even though he is my boss, he never felt distant in the typical "boss" way. Conversations with him never felt forced or formal. Somehow, he created an environment where people feel comfortable enough to be themselves. To talk honestly. To grow honestly. There's a reason why so many people around him genuinely love and respect him not because they have to, but because it happens naturally.
And I don't think he fully realizes the impact he has on people.

Sometimes we only think a salary is just money transferred at the end of the month. But for some of us, it carries much more than that.



I come from a family that has gone through its own share of difficult personal and financial challenges. So when salary day comes, it is not just a routine moment for me.
It is responsibility, relief and care all at once. It means being able to support my mother, to share a part of that weight she carries every single day and to see even a small moment of ease in her life.

That is why I've come to understand something very deeply: behind every employee, there is an entire world. Families. Responsibilities. People waiting at home. Lives that are directly shaped by what happens in the workplace.

And whether you realize it or not, Shalin, you have become a part of many of those stories.
Not in a loud or visible way, but in a very real one. Through opportunities, trust and the space you give people to grow, you are indirectly supporting more lives than you probably ever stop to calculate.

I don't think you always see the full weight of that impact, but it is there. Quiet, real and meaningful.

There is a difference between being a boss and being a leader.
A boss gives instructions.
A leader changes lives.

And I think that is exactly what you are.

Because of you, I didn't just find a workplace. I found direction, growth and a version of myself I didn't know existed yet.
And I know I'm not the only one who feels that way.

So on your birthday, this is not just a message of appreciation. It is a reflection of real moments, real changes and real gratitude from someone whose life shifted after one unexpected interview through a phone call at 5 p.m.

Wherever life takes me, I will always be grateful that I get to say this out loud!

Rusiru

Meeting You Changed Everything

About Shalin, honestly, I never know what to say because no matter what I write, it never feels enough. The easiest thing would be to say that he is kind, understanding, and one of the best bosses I have ever known. But the truth is, that doesn't even come close to capturing who he is to me.

I think what makes Shalin so special is that he has this incredible ability to make people believe in themselves, often long before they are able to do it on their own.

I spent most of my twenties at Spa Ceylon, and like most people in their twenties, the past few years came with their fair share of challenges, disappointments, losses, and moments of uncertainty. Not just in a work context, but in personal life, family, love, mental health, and what not. Through all of it, the only thing that kept me going and gave me a sense of purpose every morning was work; and if work was my safe space, it was all because of Shalin, and only him. I think it's safe to say I wouldn't have survived, much less come out the other end a better person, if it wasn't for him. He is probably the only person in my life who never gave up on me after all these years, even when I was difficult, and even when I doubted him. I've had my moments of being a total drama but he was still patient through it all.



Sometimes I think about how different my life would have been if I had never walked into that interview with him. I know one thing for certain; I would not be the person I am today, if I had never met Shalin.

So, more than anything, I am grateful. Grateful that God placed someone like him in my life when I needed it most. It is a privilege to have him in my life.

I wish Shalin a very happy birthday and many wonderful years ahead filled with happiness, good health, less stress, laughter, and all the love he deserves.

I don't think he fully realizes how many lives he has touched, but mine is definitely one of them. No matter where life takes me, I will always thank God for the day I met him. Because meeting him changed everything for me in ways I can never fully explain.

Rashmi

I'm Too Emotional To Continue Writing This...



To the birthday boy Shalin B
more than a best boss I appreciate the nice human being you are, like how you notice things about people.

The latest thing I remember is how you remembered my matcha, which I really never take granted for my life, thank you for bringing the energy to the office, I have always looked up your energy.

I HAVE SO MANY OTHER THINGS TO SAY BUT IT'S MAKES ME TOO EMOTIONAL SO CANNOT

Madumi

Becoming More Myself

Hi Shalin,

There's so much to say, but I'll try to keep it simple. You've honestly been such a big inspiration in all our lives. When I first joined, I wasn't this confident person at all (you know it), but now I find myself talking to everyone & doing things I never thought I could. A lot of that change is because of your motivation & the way you believe in me, even when I don't fully believe in myself. Thank you for that.

You've truly made an impact on me & all of us, more than you probably realise. I'm really grateful to be working with you & learning from you every day.

Happy Birthday, Shalin. Wishing you so much happiness & love always

Kavi



My Message to Shalin



Hi Shalin,
You are one of the cool bosses i have ever met. You are a very good leader, boss, mentor, friend and a truly a very good human to all of us.

I can still remember the very first day you interviewed me at Mount Lavenia office 10 years ago. Thank you for your mentorship and keeping trust on me all the time.

I wish you all the very best and a Happy Birthday.!

Asanka

To the Man Who Changed My Life

When I joined Spa Ceylon three and a half years ago, it wasn't just my first corporate job, it quietly became the beginning of everything I would grow into.

Back then, the design team was just a few of us. Today, it's a family of more than thirty designers. I've had the rare privilege of growing alongside that transformation, watching both the brand and myself evolve in the same breath. And through it all, you were there leading, shaping, and trusting.

You gave me opportunities before I ever felt ready for them. Not just tasks, but responsibility. Not just direction, but freedom. And in that space, I slowly found my voice.

Many saw risk. You saw potential.

When I joined, I could barely speak English. I could write a little, but I was never confident to speak. Even simple conversations felt like something I wanted to avoid. Even today, there are moments where I still feel that hesitation. But I know something else too, you always wanted me to speak better, to express myself with confidence, to carry myself like a gentleman.

And I want you to know this: I'm still learning, but I won't stay the same. I'll get there. I promise you that.

You never tried to change who I was instead, you refined it. You allowed me to balance worlds that rarely coexist: a corporate journey and a music life, structure and freedom, discipline and creativity. That trust became the foundation of everything I built.

Some of my earliest memories still feel like stories I'll tell forever, market setups where we were building things from scratch, late nights that turned into early mornings, shoots where nothing felt fully certain but everything felt alive. I still remember you walking in at dawn, checking details quietly, guiding us while the world was still asleep.

One memory that always makes me smile is our Anuradhapura shoot. I still remember bringing dinner from my home and sharing it together, far away from everything. It was just a simple moment. But those are often the moments that stay with us the longest. The human moments. The moments that remind us that work is ultimately about people.

What stays with me most is not just what we built - but how you shaped people while building it.

I've seen it in the way you speak, the way you act, and the way people change after



working with you. I've heard it in stories, like Gihan ayya's journey and how your guidance shaped his path. I've seen it in people who stayed ten, fifteen years, not because they had to, but because they believed.

That kind of loyalty is never accidental.

It comes from trust. From consistency. From people feeling seen.

And you and your brother built that - not just a brand, but a culture people belong to.

What inspires me most is your balance.

You are calm, easygoing, and fully present in life, someone who knows how to enjoy it. Yet when it's time to build, your focus never slips. You don't miss details. You don't lose direction. You don't compromise vision. That duality is rare. And it taught me something I will carry forever: you don't have to choose between living and building - you can do both, fully.

When I look at Spa Ceylon, I don't just see growth or success.

I see people who became more because you believed in them and when I look at myself, I see someone still becoming slowly, quietly, but surely.

Thank you for trusting me before I had reasons to deserve it. Thank you for the freedom, the lessons, the patience, and the memories that don't feel like work anymore.

Happy Birthday, Shalin.

You did both and that changes everything!

"

SOME PEOPLE BUILD COMPANIES.

SOME PEOPLE BUILD PEOPLE.

YOU DID BOTH & THAT CHANGES EVERYTHING!

Sheran



The First Conversation



I don't think I have ever told you this properly,
but that first proper conversation I had with you stayed with me more than you probably realise.

I still remember walking into the office that day. I had an appointment with you a little later, maybe in about thirty minutes, and you were heading out for lunch. You saw me, stopped, and brought me in anyway. That became my first real conversation with you.

What I remember most is that it was hardly about the role. I don't think I asked much about the role either. It felt more like you wanted to understand who I was first, before anything else. How I thought, how I spoke, and what kind of person I was. Not just whether I fit the role, but whether I would fit into the way you worked.

And honestly, I needed that too.

I was still uneasy at that point. New place, new people, new expectations, and you were not just another manager. You were the boss. So naturally, there was pressure. But that conversation gave me some assurance. Not because you made anything sound easy. You didn't. It was more in the way you spoke and listened.



I walked out feeling that if I did the work properly, I would not be left hanging. I remember thinking, "I can work with him."
I have told that story to a few people I work closely with here because it stayed with me. From the outside, it may have looked like a normal conversation. For me, it settled something.

Three years later, I think what I have understood most is how consistent you are.
You always say, "Come early." If there is a problem, come early. If we need help, come early. If we need something to make the work happen, come early. Not because you expect people to have all the answers, but because you want enough time to help find one.

That is something I have seen again and again. You break things down, ask the right questions, and guide people toward a solution. At the same time, you also teach us not to come empty-handed. Come with an idea, a possible solution, or at least another way forward.

And honestly, even when we don't come early, or when we royally mess something up, including me, you still help clean it up. Of course, we may get an earful first, and most of the time we probably deserve it. You will remind us that it should have come earlier, and you are usually right.

But what I respect is that you don't hold grudges. You don't keep pointing back to old mistakes once the lesson is learned. You scold when it is needed, then you do what a good leader does. You help fix what can be fixed, make sure we understand where we went wrong, and then let us move forward.
I have had moments where I was not fully sure of myself, and moments where I messed things up, but I never felt like I had to figure it out alone.

There is also that funny feeling where you are handling something yourself, but when it really matters, you still think, "I need to take this to Shalin." It is like that meme where you are a manager, but your manager is Manager Pro Max. Except in this case, it is The Boss.

And somehow, even with everything on your plate, you still give the time.
What stands out even more is that I have seen this most clearly in personal moments. With work, there is usually a way to plan, come back, break it down, or fix the next step. But when someone needs a few minutes personally, you seem to understand that it cannot always wait.

You have given me that time a few times too. And what stayed with me is that it was not only in that moment. Even later, you remembered the details. You remembered what was said, what mattered, and where I was at.

When someone needs those eight minutes, you give them those eight minutes properly. Not in a dramatic way, and not by making a big show of it. You just listen. You may have a packed day, people waiting, calls coming in, and ten other things happening, but in that moment, you still make the person feel heard.
That is not a small thing.

"Break it down" is something I have carried with me. When something feels too big, or when there are too many moving parts, break it down and find the next step.
You might forget names, sometimes more than once, but somehow you remember the conversations that matter.

Looking back, I don't think you have changed much from that first conversation to now. I just understand you better now.
At the start, I saw the pressure. Now I understand the support behind it.

Happy Birthday, Shalin.

Thank you for that first conversation.

Zaeem

Daddy: The Corporate Father Figure Situation



This may sound weird but striving to gain your acceptance used to be my main goal when I first joined here. Idk why that was (maybe for the lack of an approving father figure in my life or something) but it was what kept me going. The thought of "how do I seem good enough for him?" was mantra for me. And like you've said I wasn't someone who was going to stay here for long it changed that night at the butterfly paradise immersive experience where you randomly told me to come up with a video idea, and it shocked me that you even considered me to head anything. And since then I've been trying to be better to get that from you again. And I'd like to think I've done at least something right or grown in some way, cus you kept opening doors for me. And it's always something bigger, so essentially I'm chasing a high and the only way I can do it is by increasing the dose lol.

HOW DO I SEEM GOOD ENOUGH FOR HIM?

I'm not someone who wants acknowledgement but you've given it anyway and it's helped me grow more confident in what I'm good at and everything you've done for me has further tuned what I really want to do in life. My career here is built on nothing but absolute gratitude because I genuinely would not have been anything if not for the opportunities you've kept giving me. Idk what you saw / see in me (I still don't and I have a hard time believing that you're not just lying to make me feel better) but you've told me things that generally should come from my therapists or my parents and I'm really grateful for the way your words have pulled me back up put things into perspective in me when things aren't the best.

I know I lose track and have an identity crisis on and off but thank you for your faith in me, it's nice to know someone is out there who's not giving up on you. I'm also sorry sometimes and that I talk back when you want me to just shut up and listen, it's just that sometimes I get too excited about projects and I forget that at the end of the day I'm working for you lol. Also this isn't meant to sound like glaze over, but of everyone I've worked with in office (with the exception of Sharon) I like working with you the most, not because you're easy to work with but I feel like I can express myself the best with you. And I'm looking forward to keeping doing that if you will have me.

Anyway thank you so much again I truly appreciate you. To close this off I want to attach my favourite message that you've sent me.



This was so weird to write.
Happy Birthday.

Suarez



The Version The World Doesn't See



Wishing you a very happy birthday Shalin!
I have said it before but will say it again, as it means a lot.
Thank you for making office a safe place to work in. Not only for me but for all of us.
Thank you for always pushing my limits to learn, as I can get stubborn and settle in my comfort zone.
Being honest I always thought Shalin was a brand ambassador for Spa Ceylon. I heard him speak just a couple of times and would not finish the video.
When I applied for the role of PA for the Marketing Director, I applied not knowing anything about the person, just went with my gut feeling. Glad I applied.
On the day of the first virtual interview, was I in for a shocker. The person who was on the Spa Ceylon videos was interviewing me. I still remember when I asked for his name, I believe I did see an eye roll and thought to myself, righto, there goes the job.
Cutting forward to me being at Spa Ceylon, it took a good year for me to learn about Shalin, his ways, how he wants work to be handled. It was a learning for sure, one that I enjoyed and did not at the same time.
Shalin Balasuriya, no one else like him.

Wishing you a very happy birthday Shalin!
I have said it before but will say it again, as it means a lot. Thank you for making office a safe place to work in. Not only for me but for all of us.
Thank you for always pushing my limits to learn, as I can get stubborn and settle in my comfort zone.
Thank you for always being patient with me.
You have a caring heart and is not seen by the outside world.
I am not a person to take pride in designations but I am proud to say that I am your PA.
Here's to wishing you a long healthy life, filled with smiles, surprises and most of all love from the people who care.

PK

The Safest Office To Cry In

I recently went through my first notebook that I brought to office (keep in mind this was my first corporate job) and my god was I a bundle of stress. Literally everything seemed to be a case of life and death and almost on every page I've just written down, ask for Shalin's advice or talk to Shalin.

When I first joined I never actually thought I could ever run production, I had no idea what I was doing, and it felt super daunting. But every single time I needed help, you would actually hear me out, and the worst case scenario is that we postponed this discussion.

December to February was a very tough stretch in my personal life and you noticed Shalin, you asked me if I was doing okay and you actively checked up on me. Something that not even most friends do, my boss was doing for me. And it wasn't just lending an ear, it was always a discussion and I think I ended up crying like 9/10 times when I came back from your office lol. To be honest it's very easy to accidentally take you for granted because you're not the type of person who demands respect, or results. Every failure I've had within the company was only super scary because I didn't want to disappoint you, not because you would terminate and berate me. And I think that's the same for a lot of people in the office.



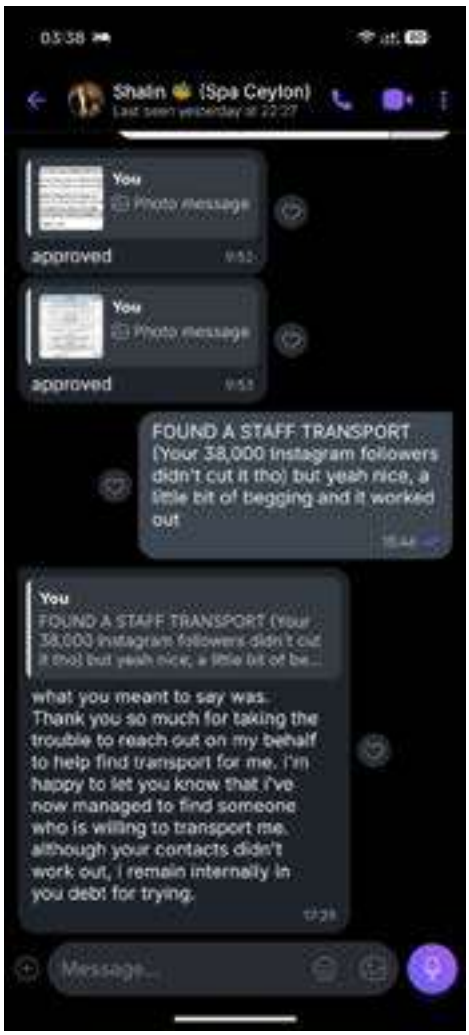
Honestly sometimes I wish you would just freaking scold me instead, it's so much worse having someone so supportive be disappointed in you after they whole heartedly believe in you.

Anyway... If we were to chart my growth ever since I've joined Spa Ceylon, and if we had two plots, one for personal growth and one for work efficacy, you'll see that my personal growth has just exponentially increased and just keeps on increasing (let's not talk about the work growth plotline shall we).

I used to get super anxious when I received a phone call and now I get calls from randoms literally everyday. I used to always think I'm not capable of doing something and now the only limiting factor for me is do we have the time or budget to do this?

I love you Shalin! We all do, and I really hope you know that. I think you've nailed the whole cool boss dynamic and I doubt anyone else in the world does it better than you do (lol what do I know tho, I've only worked here) I brag about you to my family lol. Hope you'll always keep

Adhitha

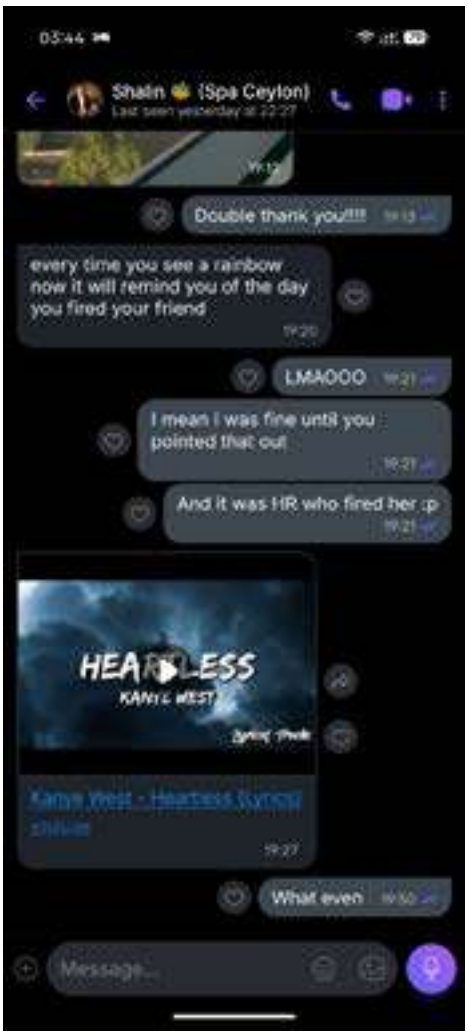

Shalin (Spa Ceylon)
You
Photo message
approved
You
Photo message
approved
FOUND A STAFF TRANSPORT (Your 38,000 Instagram followers didn't cut it tho) but yeah nice, a little bit of begging and it worked out
You
FOUND A STAFF TRANSPORT (Your 38,000 Instagram followers didn't cut it tho) but yeah nice, a little bit of be...
what you meant to say was. Thank you so much for taking the trouble to reach out on my behalf to help find transport for me. i'm happy to let you know that i've now managed to find someone who is willing to transport me. although your contacts didn't work out, I remain internally in you debt for trying.
Message...


Shalin (Spa Ceylon)
i need to bill you guys for shoots
you look like nice guy, I give yo good price
Faaaaair enough
this dood
I've been trained to negotiate
keep track of the dates i'll give you an invoice
Kindly include the following details in your invoice:
Name
Address
NIC
Contact Number
Invoice Number
Date
Bank Name and Branch
Brief description of the work done
Signature
VAT number if applicable
Payment Terms:
Payments will only be processed once the campaign has ended invoices will be sent in for
Message...


Shalin (Spa Ceylon)
approved
is that the dog in the pic
Shalin (Spa Ceylon)
is that the dog in the pic
Whaaa?
Shalin (Spa Ceylon)
approved
Thankyouuu
Did I tell you about this zoo I went to in europe ?
This is a trap
But no you haven't...
Enlighten me
it was strange. it just had one dog
it was a shit-zoo
My dog is literally a TIBETAN TERRIER.
Message...


Shalin (Spa Ceylon)
TERRIER.
oh from Tibet, so a Buddhist Shih-tzu then.
15 Dec 2025
Corks
Types and differences
I'm so confused
19 Dec 2025
Message...


Shalin (Spa Ceylon)
Thank you!!
Double thank you!!!!
every time you see a rainbow now it will remind you of the day you fired your friend
Message...


Shalin (Spa Ceylon)
Double thank you!!!!
every time you see a rainbow now it will remind you of the day you fired your friend
LMAOOO
I mean I was fine until you pointed that out
And it was HR who fired her :p
HEARTLESS
KANYE WEST
What even
Message...


Shalin (Spa Ceylon)
get some sun
Will doooo, did so yesterday too. But damn these are some hot days 👀
Don't be a pale, whiny bitch!
Bruh
Shalin requesting your approval to get the following items on a 100% discount basis to urgently shoot content today.
Neem & Tea tree day protector
True turmeric vit c glow day protector
Lotus and Rambutan day protector
White Jasmine day protector
White Rice day protector
Sal & Safron day protector
Virgin Coconut - Cream Facial Wash
True Turmeric - Vitamin C Glow - Facial Cleansing Foam
Sal & Saffron - Vitamin E Rich Facial Cleansing Foam
Message...


shalin.b
Business chat
is that maheli ?
Yesss
she has lost so much weight since you stole her job
sade.g
Message...

The Streets of Sri Lanka Are Safer Now Because of You

Nowadays, when I look at social media, I see many popular people sharing how they think, how they look at systems, and how they see the world. I have followed people like that since my childhood, and I have learned a lot through self-study by watching this type of content.

After I joined Spa Ceylon, very randomly, I got the chance to listen to your "Break It Down" lesson. That lesson hit me in a very different way. Many times, when a task became complicated, I used to skip it and start something else. But after hearing your lesson, I started actually breaking tasks down step by step, and it worked.

I was also very aggressive when riding my bike. Many times, I created unnecessary trouble with people on the road. But after watching your TikTok, where you spoke about someone possibly going to the hospital, that story stayed in my mind. Now, before getting into road conflicts, I think about that story. I give people space on the road and take my vehicle back calmly.

"Be careful about the story you tell yourself." This was golden for me. One of my biggest problems in life was English. For a long time, I did not give myself the chance to use English because I had a fear that if I spoke broken English, people would laugh at me. But after hearing that story, I realized it was not really about people laughing. It was about the story I was telling myself. I gradually changed that mindset. I started speaking without thinking it was impossible.

I am saying this specially because, as I told you before, Sri Lanka has many influencers and content creators now. I also listen to many of them, but only a few people have given me lessons that actually changed my life. First of all, thank you, Shalin.

Also, I want to make a small request. If possible, please do monthly lessons like you did before and add more content like this to social media, especially content that can help people think differently and improve their lives. Also, if possible, please use a better mic

Thank you for all the chances and opportunities you gave me. In these three years, I have actually changed a lot in my life.

Happy Birthday, Shalin. I wish you all the best.

Dishan

> "BE CAREFUL ABOUT THE STORY YOU TELL YOURSELF



You Are Inspiring

Hi Shalin,
I just wanted to take a moment to say thank you, and to let you know how incredibly grateful I am for the opportunity you gave me. Looking back on the past year at Marketing HQ, getting the chance to learn under your leadership has genuinely been so inspiring.

Working under your guidance has pushed me in ways I never expected. I've had the opportunity to do things I never thought I would be trusted to do, and honestly, things I never thought I was even capable of doing.

That growth and confidence that you have had in the influencer team is something I'll always be grateful for.

Thank you for being one of the most charismatic, creative, and humble bosses I've had the pleasure of working with. Your leadership and vision have truly made an impact on me, and I'll always appreciate everything I've learned here.
Cheers to the future!

Terah

Meow Meow

Shalin has always had his own funny way of making people feel comfortable , including calling me "meow meow me". Still not sure how I earned that title, but I'll take it.

In the first few years, I was honestly scared to talk to him. Now, it feels much easier, mostly because he has a way of listening, trusting, and letting people figure things out

What I appreciate most is the trust he has in our small Luvesence team , somehow believing we can pull off big things with a tiny team.

Happy Birthday, Shalin!

Miyumi

"

MEOW MEOW ME





The Collection of Small Moments

The funny thing is, when we think about Shalin, we don't immediately think about campaigns, meetings or deadlines. We think about the random comments that became inside jokes, the calm voice when everyone else was overcomplicating something, and the chats that somehow drifted far beyond work.

One thing we've always appreciated is that they never felt transactional. You could be discussing a campaign one minute and laughing about something completely unrelated the next. There isn't one defining story that sums up Shalin. It's more a collection of small moments that have quietly piled up. The reminders, often without saying them directly, that work is important but it's not the only thing that matters.

And looking back, those are the moments that have stayed with us the most.

International ad girlies (Liyana, Vihara, Maneka, Rashmi)

To the Diamond of Every Season



Dearest Gentle Reader, Did you miss me?
Surely there could not be a magazine without my contribution to it. After all, what is a publication without a little gossip and admiration? (Wink)

Today's edition is dedicated to none other than the Diamond of every season, a gentleman who finds himself celebrating his 40th birthday once again. Though between us, it was decided long ago that he shall remain 40 forever.
As one of the longest-serving members of this society, I have had the privilege of witnessing many seasons unfold.

And I am proud to report that each one has been better than the last, thanks in no small part to you.

I still remember the day I discovered that you were part of Janet. Before that, I knew you only from television and your memorable interviews. So imagine my surprise when I saw you casually walking through Parkland. It is safe to say I was completely starstruck.

The sessions you conducted at Parkland and Rotunda may have seemed the greatest all the time, they left a lasting impression on many of us. They gave me confidence, taught me valuable lessons, and provided knowledge that I continue to use to this very day.

Yet, among all the memories, one stands above the rest.

There was a time when I was afraid to take the lead at Janet. I doubted myself and questioned whether I was capable. You noticed what I could not see in myself. You told me not to doubt my abilities because you believed I could do the job and do it well. Then you said something I will never forget:

"If you doubt yourself, you're doubting me."

Now, how could anyone possibly doubt
Mr. Shalin Balasooriya?

You have created opportunities for so many people, inspired confidence when it was needed most, and made this workplace a place filled with growth, laughter, and unforgettable memories.

For all of that, and so much more, thank you.

Happy Birthdayy, Big Boss.

Yours truly,

A grateful member of the ton.

What It Feels Like To Be Seen

There's something I never actually said to you, mostly because I didn't know how and partly because I wasn't sure you'd even remember the moments I'm talking about.

I came in thinking I knew where I was headed. Ceylon Elephant Co. was the plan. I had it mapped out in my head the way you do when you're new somewhere and you need the certainty of a direction. And then things shifted , new team, new scope, whole new vocabulary to learn and for a while I was just quietly trying not to look as lost as I felt.

I don't think I told anyone that. I don't think I even fully admitted it to myself.

What I never got to say is this: you noticed before I did. I don't know what you saw , maybe it was obvious from the outside, the way these things usually are but whatever it was, you didn't make it a moment. You didn't sit me down. You just started opening doors. A new team here, a different kind of work there. Small things that probably felt like nothing from your end.

From my end , it felt like someone saying you belong here without using those words.

I think that's what I'll carry. Not a big conversation, not a defining speech. Just the quiet fact that someone busy enough to look away , didn't.

You probably don't realise you did it. That's the part that gets me most.

Happy Birthday. I hope someone does that for you today. notices something you didn't know you needed, and just quietly shows up for it.

Nathalie Hettiarachchi



Most People Look at Buildings. You Look at People.

I wasn't sure if I should write this because I've only been here for four months still.

One thing I've never told anyone is that before I joined, I genuinely thought you were going to be one of those bosses who walks around making everyone nervous for no reason. The kind of people they warn you about before your first day. Turns out I was completely wrong (to be fair this is my first official job and those movies I have been watching gave me a whole other impression)

The thing I remember most oddly is actually something Shanela told me within the first few days I started. She said that when you travel, you sit in malls and just watch people.At the time I thought, "How weird and creepy it is you travelled all the way there to sit in a mall?" And I blurted out that it was creepy and when you passed by her office she told you what I said and I was like oh noo (kinda freaking out), but somehow that story has lived (and will keep living) rent-free in my head ever since. The older I get, the more I realise that's actually a pretty cool way to see the world and try to understand people .Most people look at buildings. You look at people.

And I think that's probably why Spa Ceylon feels the way it does.

You've built something huge, but somehow you're still around. You're still walking through the office, noticing things and noticing people.Most founders at this stage would probably be hiding behind ten meetings and an assistant (is what I have imagined). What I don't think you realise is that people notice that.

As someone who's only just starting her career, it's been cool to see what leadership looks like when it isn't loud.

I probably won't remember every task I did as an intern here. But I'll remember the people, the culture and the feeling of working somewhere that was built with actual passion behind it.

Happy Birthday and please continue your international mall-sitting observing research. It seems to be working.

From your intern, who can no longer walk through a mall without wondering what stories the people around her have

Athini





"

You chose me.
You trusted me.
You made me who I am.
There's no Gihan without you, Sir.
Thank you so much, and I love you so much.

- Gihan





My name is not Tasha...

There are probably hundreds of people who know Shalin as a co-founder, but one of the things I'll always remember is his ongoing mission to get me to stop wearing black.

I wear black almost every day. Without fail, whenever I show up in something that isn't black, he'll notice. Not in a passing way either. There's genuine excitement, as if I've made some life-changing decision overnight. It's become such a running joke that now I almost expect a comment whenever I wear colour.

What has always stood out to me, though, is how present he is.

For someone who carries the responsibilities that come with building and running a company, he somehow never walks past our table without stopping to say something. Sometimes it's a joke, sometimes it's a random comment, sometimes it's just enough to make everyone laugh and reset after a stressful morning. They're small moments, but they change the mood of a day more than people realise.

You never leave a conversation feeling dismissed or foolish for asking a question. What I appreciate most is that he doesn't just hear opinions, he values them. He has a way of making people feel like their perspective matters, regardless of their role or title.

There is one detail I should mention for the sake of accuracy, Shalin has one very consistent blind spot: names.

After almost two years, Shalin still calls me "Tasha."

Somehow, though, the same person who can't quite get my name right will immediately notice when I've decided not to wear black.

If you're reading this Shalin, it's Thashiya or Thash, still.

Thash

WHAT STAYED WITH ME

From the people who left with more than memories. The ones who carried your lessons, your words and parts of your way of seeing the world into the rest of their lives.




YOU SAID,
WHAT YOU DID,
RGET HOW YOU



The Things You Carry Into The Rest Of Your Life

No titles. No status.
Just a genuinely kind person sharing what he had with others.

"

"YOU'RE YOUNG. YOU HAVE A LONG WAY TO GO.

THINK BIGGER."

When I think about Shalin, the first thing that comes to mind isn't a meeting, a campaign or even work. It's a memory that happened last year.

He came to my apartment and cooked for Hashena, Tuli and me because we missed Sri Lanka.

It might sound like a simple thing, but it wasn't. He was someone who owned a business, traveled the world, achieved so much professionally and yet was humble enough to walk into a former employee's apartment and cook a meal. There was no hierarchy in that moment. No titles. No status. Just a genuinely kind person sharing what he had with others.

I've never really spoken about that memory before but it's one of the moments that best captures who Shalin is to me. It showed me that success means very little if you lose your ability to connect with people.

One lesson that has stayed with me throughout my career came from my time at Spa Ceylon. Shalin used to say, "It's about how you make them feel."

At the time, I understood it in the context of marketing and customer experience. But over the years, I've realized it applies to almost everything in life.
Whether it's a guest, a colleague, a client or even someone you meet for the first time, people remember how you made them feel long after they forget everything else.



Even today, whenever I attend interviews or start something new, that's a lesson I carry with me. It's one of those rare pieces of advice that never stopped being relevant.

I joined Spa Ceylon when I was only 19 years old. From the very beginning, Shalin would constantly remind me,
"You're young. You have a long way to go. Think bigger."

At the time, I probably rolled my eyes more than once. But looking back, I realize he was always encouraging me to see more potential in myself than I could see. Even now, at 23, those words still sit somewhere in the back of my mind whenever I'm making decisions about my future.

Of course, I can't write this without mentioning the hilarious joke he constantly makes about my A-Levels. Somehow, no matter how much time passes, Shalin always finds a way to bring up the fact that I never did them. To this day, I still wonder, if that was such a problem, why did you hire me in the first place? Well, technically, you didn't. Shanela did. So I guess that explains it.

But I think that's what made working with him enjoyable. There was always room for laughter, even while learning.

Another thing I learned from him was that no matter what happens behind the scenes, disagreements, challenges, pressure or chaos the work still needs to get done. The result matters. The audience only sees what you deliver, not everything that happened in the background.

More than anything though, I admire how easily Shalin connects with people. It's a quality that can't be taught. People trust him, feel comfortable around him, and learn from him because he genuinely cares.

I wish there were more people like that. More people willing to teach, mentor, listen and continue learning themselves. One thing I've always respected about Shalin is that despite all his experience, he has never stopped being curious. He's always willing to learn something new.

I've never really said any of this out loud before but if there's one thing I'd want people to know about Shalin, it's this: his impact on people goes far beyond work. The lessons stay. The memories stay. And for many of us, so does the confidence he helped build.

Happy Birthday, Shalin.

Thank you for the lessons, the laughs, the belief and for reminding young people like me to think bigger than we think we can.

Reshana



Here...

I have way too many memories with Shalin to pick just one. Honestly, choosing a favourite memory feels a bit like choosing a favourite child, except I don't have children, so let's move on.

One memory that always stands out happened when we were working at LuvEsence. We had a lot of activations back then, and I was usually the one on the ground making sure everything was running smoothly. On one particular day, I had a haircut appointment after work, and at the time, salaries had a habit of arriving whenever they felt like it. Payday wasn't really a day; it was more of a surprise.

I remember sitting with Shalin during lunch at TGIF in OGF, stressing about the fact that I still hadn't received my salary and didn't have any cash for the haircut. Lol! Priorities. I had to leave by 5:30 p.m. and was messaging the person responsible for depositing the salaries, who kept saying, "another 10 minutes." Now, if you've ever lived through "another 10 minutes" in Sri Lanka, you know that could mean absolutely anything.



I don't know, I just always look forward to the fun chats.

And of course, I have to address the elephant, or rather, the crab in the room. Shalin's so-called famous crab curry. For the longest time, I thought I was imagining it.
But apparently not. The man can lead teams, inspire people, and apparently cook a killer crab curry... which I had to beg him to make for years.

Thank you Shalin, finally.

More than anything, Shalin has this rare ability to make people feel seen, heard, and valued.
He has a genuinely beautiful heart, and that's what makes him so special. The crab curry is a close second, but the heart wins.

HBD Shalin!

Hashena

Shalin asked me how much I needed. I don't even think I answered properly, but a few moments later, he transferred LKR 15,000 into my account. Five minutes after that, my actual salary came through, and I immediately sent the money back to him.

What stayed with me wasn't the money; it was the fact that helping someone came so naturally to him. No hesitation, no questions, no drama. Just pure kindness. That's the thing about Shalin. He's incredibly human. If I ever end up in a position of power, I'd want to be the kind of leader people describe the way they describe him.

He's also one of the few people I've met who can start a Teams call about work at 4 p.m. and somehow end it at 7 p.m., answering all my questions about life. There have been countless conversations where I'd ask him random questions about life, work, people, or whatever existential crisis I was dealing with that week, and he'd patiently answer. Looking back, I think that was when the Spa Ceylon podcast really started (good job, Hashena!). I guess I was prepping him for the future. It's just that my questions were better than Danu's.
And then there are all the things people have told me about him over the years. I've genuinely never heard anyone say a bad word about Shalin. Except for one person (you know who... lol).
Even now, whenever he comes to Dubai, I look forward to seeing him. It feels like catching up with an old friend and a mentor.



A Moment That Stayed With Me

"

"You are very strong & tough on exterior probably because you are very sensitive in your heart.

May be you are covering it up to protect your heart"

I have cried at his desk twice. Once on the day I am gonna talk about below & on my last day…..

Once this particular day, I spoke to him in tears & he listened. Listened very carefully & attentively. I said something that struck through my ears & went & hit exactly where it should hit.

It hit deep..!!!! He told me:

"You are very strong & tough on exterior probably because you are very sensitive in your heart. May be you are covering it up to protect your heart"

THE level of reading he had on me I never expected was right there in front me to realize the understanding he had on me from that single line he told despite all my guards & high walls I built around me.

He is someone who would always have one of the top most seats in my life forever & forever.

The respect I have for him is so much!

P.S.: I have cried in front of handful of people in my entire life & in handful of times. I rarely cry coz it takes a great deal for me to be that loosen up in front of anyone. So me being able to cry in front of Shalin not once but twice says a lot about the place he has in my life I guess.

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G

A Manager Like No Other



The only person who probably wants me back in Sri Lanka more than my own parents.
The only manager I've ever compared others to – because he raised the bar that high.
A reputed businessman in Sri Lanka who somehow talks more politics with me than business.
And the person who trusted me in everything I did, even when half the time I had no idea what I was doing.

Forever grateful!

HOPING TO SEE 46 WOMEN PUT TO SLEEP AT THE SAME TIME, SINCE I CAN COURIER TRUMP'S NOBLE PEACE PRIZE MYSELF, BECAUSE I HAVE NO PLANS OF COMING BACK ANYTIME SOON.

PS: HBD!

Vishmith

A Greeting That Meant Everything

One of the cutest memories I have of Shalin is the way he would say, "Hi, TikTok Star!" whenever he walked past me while I was making TikToks alone after finishing my work.
To him, it might have been just a small greeting, but to me, it was a huge source of motivation. It made me feel seen and valued and it reminded me that my presence mattered. It also inspired me to keep trying new things and work harder, hoping to earn more of his appreciation.
When I think of Shalin, I will always remember him as someone who knew how to lead a team by appreciating people, making them feel valued and bringing excitement into their lives through the smallest gestures and words.
Thank you for those memories and happy birthday, Shalin!

Udeni



A Birthday Memory to Remember



Even after my famous 2 million spending incident, he never once looked at me differently.

Happy Birthday, Shalin! How could I ever forget the biggest birthday surprise I gave you on your birthday?
I somehow managed to spend my entire monthly UK budget in just four days, a cool 2 million, and only realized it on Shalin's birthday.
To this day, that's one memory I'll never forget.

What stands out most is that while I was absolutely bawling my eyes out, Shalin somehow managed to see the positive side of it (along with a fair bit of bugging, of course). Looking back, that moment says a lot about who he is.

I'm incredibly grateful for the opportunities he gave me to step outside my comfort zone and for always having his door open. Even after my famous 2 million spending incident, he never once looked at me differently. Any other boss might have sent me home or judged me for it, but instead, he chose to support me. I still remember a time when I was feeling really low, and he reminded me that it's important to tell people how you're feeling because HQ stands by its people. That has always stayed with me.

People may forget what you said and what you did, but they'll never forget how you made them feel. Shalin's door was always open, whether it was for work, advice, or just a chat, and that's something rare.

I genuinely wouldn't be where I am today without Shalin and the culture at HQ. I walked in as someone who was terrified of public speaking and never saw herself as a leader. Somehow, I ended up doing both. One thing I always laugh about is that I



genuinely don't know what it's like to get scolded by Shalin. No matter how many times I messed up (and yes, including the 2 million), he never once raised his voice at me. He understood people, understood how to approach them, and always chose encouragement over intimidation.

I'm proud to have worked so closely with such a cool boss, someone who constantly bugs you about the Prophet and the Miracle Dome, but at the same time sees your potential, pushes you to grow, and gives you the space to become more than you thought you could be.

Thank you for all the opportunities, the patience, the trust, and the many chances. Wishing you continued success and God's blessings in everything you do, Shalin. Hoping I'll see you at the Dome someday.

Happy Birthday.

Eleesha

"

HE ALWAYS CHOSE ENCOURAGEMENT OVER INTIMIDATION.

Aye Bonna Denna Epa

After June 2023, Mal Pan Podak never brought back any memories for me other than the feeling of singing it in front of the whole JAM for Shalin's Birthday! I still remember the smile on Shalin's face while I was singing it! Since then, it's officially Shalin's song to me.
I'll never forget the way Shalin used to say, "Sanduni can write a song for this campaign," whenever he joined our brainstormings!

That's actually how I started writing jingles for campaigns, even though I couldn't write one for LuvEsence at the time.
I still remember the very first day I met the one & only Shalin Balasooriya at the Parkland Building LuvEsence room. I was very nervous. He was explaining something to us and suddenly pointed at me and Miyumi, who were both wearing glasses, and said, "You two look like twins!" From that day onwards, we became twins!

The funniest and most embarrassing story No. 2 is that I got so drunk and extra confident at the JANET anniversary party (where I did a deodorant photoshoot for free, according to Shanela) and pointed at Shalin and said,
"Hey, there's a Bollywood actor who looks exactly like you!" Drunk me immediately Googled the actor and showed him the photo. His name was Sonu Sood! For a moment, I completely forgot how big Shalin is, and I was just yapping away while he simply laughed.

And story number one!! Everyone on my team still remembers how I PUKED in front of Shalin. The next day, he pointed at me and said, "Sandunita aye bonna denne na!"

One of the country's biggest entrepreneurs, whose days are packed with endless work, still found time to care about each and every member of his team. I still remember the goodbye message and well wishes he sent me on my last day at Marketing HQ, even though he wasn't in Sri Lanka at the time.
"Who | Do | Feel" is a lifetime lesson that has helped me more than any bachelor's degree ever could. Even today, every time I pass a Spa Ceylon store or see a JANET or LuvEsence product rack in a supermarket, I feel incredibly proud. I couldn't be more grateful for that feeling.
So, simply, thank you for being that Person!

Happy Birthday! Waiting to sing "Mal Pan Podak" again soon!



"

HEY, THERE'S A BOLLYWOOD ACTOR WHO LOOKS EXACTLY LIKE YOU!

Sanduni

The Girl Who Came Out of a CUBE

My first conversation with Shalin happened in the elevator on my way up to the office. He asked me my name and where I had worked before. I told him I had come from Rubiq Creatives.
"Oh, I've heard of it," he said. For some reason, that was enough to make it one of the most terrifying conversations I'd had. Small talk was never my strength.

The next day, he called me in for a chat. The first thing he said was, "You used to work at some sort of cube, right?" I nearly burst out laughing. During that
conversation, he asked me about my strengths and weaknesses.
I admitted that I was terrible at making small talk. He told me that at Marketing HQ, small talk was an everyday thing and

that within a month, I'd turn that weakness into a strength.

I wasn't convinced. But he was right.

Looking back, one of the most memorable lessons I took away from Shalin wasn't about marketing or work.
It was the confidence to start a conversation, something that once terrified me and now feels completely natural.

Amalna

Handsome Boss Energy

I've learned a lot from you, especially how to think out of the box.

You always said it's okay to make mistakes, but not to repeat the same mistake twice. I really remember that and even after doing something silly, I just remind myself and move on.

And honestly, we also had a little pride saying, 'අපිට තමයි handsome boss ඉන්නෙ'
Most importantly, I learned that people may forget what you said or did but they will never forget how you made them feel.
The vibe and culture you created in the office is still something I carry with me even today.

Wishing you a very happy birthday Shalin.
Hope this year brings you more success, good health and lots of good moments.

Ayesha



"අපිට තමයි **handsome boss** ඉන්නේ"

Because You Believed

"

YOU'D SIT THERE WONDERING,

HOW DOES HE THINK I CAN DO THIS WHEN I KNOW I CAN'T?



Some memories are moments.
But when I think about Shalin, what comes to mind are lessons, lifelong ones. Before I met him, I was never someone who explored the unknown or willingly stepped outside my comfort zone. And if I ever had to, my face would have subtitles before my mouth even uttered a word.

That slowly began to change after working with Shalin.

Although "working" feels like the wrong word to use, because with him, work never really felt like work. It felt like growth. Growing with Shalin.

Shalin always believed in me — and in everyone around him. He saw something in people that they often couldn't see in themselves. He had this unwavering faith, patience and trust.
Sometimes it almost felt blind to us. You'd sit there wondering, How does he think I can do this when I know I can't?

But somehow, slowly and subtly, he would prove you wrong.

The funny thing is, you don't even realise you're changing while it's happening. One day, you suddenly become the person you once thought you couldn't be.

That faith, patience, and trust changed my life in ways far beyond work. It created a ripple effect that shaped the decisions I make, the risks I take, and the person I continue to become.

Shalin never says no, unless you're chasing something truly fruitless or reckless. He always sees the bigger picture.

From the very first day I joined, he recognised that creativity was my strength — a God-given gift. But he also recognised what I lacked: logic, strategy, numbers, structure. And whether I liked it or not, no matter how much I sighed, complained, or even cried about it, he kept pushing me toward those things.

At the time, I didn't understand why.

Now I do.

Because it made me stronger at what I do today.

But more importantly, he pushed me toward the things I was passionate about even the things that scared me.

One of the biggest examples of that was the Sip & Paint experience he trusted me with at Spa Ceylon. At the time, it felt intimidating stepping into something so personal and creatively vulnerable.



But Shalin had this way of seeing potential before you saw it yourself. He gave me the confidence to pursue something I genuinely loved, while reminding me that creativity deserved space beyond fear and self-doubt.

That opportunity became more than just an event. It became proof that passion is worth pursuing, even when it feels uncomfortable at first.

And honestly, the best way to explain Shalin is through something as simple as food.

I have the taste buds of a five-year-old. I could survive on french fries and cheese sandwiches forever. I would make a face before even tasting something unfamiliar and automatically decide I wouldn't like it.

Then came our Singapore trip.

Shalin ordered a buffet filled with everything I *don't* eat — with fried rice sitting there as my safe backup option, I suppose. But he made me try everything.

And ever since then, look who's eating dumplings and satay now.

At first, it was about food. But eventually I realised it was never just about food.

It was about learning to try. To take the first step. To explore what scares you. To stop rejecting things before giving them a chance.

Today, working in hospitality, that lesson helps me every single day. If I don't like something, I can always leave it. But at least I'll try.

And that mindset no longer applies just to food. It applies to my passions, my dreams, my career and the life I want to build for myself.

I wanted to see the world, and Shalin helped me do that too.

I've had some real "godayata magic" moments because of him, and I can never be grateful enough for every single one of them. He looked after us like family, right down to carrying my rusty, broken suitcase with one missing wheel through one of the world's prettiest airports.

Every little thing added to his character: his humility, his strength, his patience and his love for people.

In just two years of knowing him, Shalin has had one of the biggest impacts on my life — alongside my parents and a very select few people I hold close to my heart.

And for that, I will always be grateful.

Thank you for all the good you do for the world, for the people around you and for believing in us long before we believed in ourselves.

Happy Birthday, Shalin.

Kavi



A Life in Creative Chaos

Shalin is as colourful as the brand he co-founded, and working with him is often like a rollercoaster ride - equal parts fun, challenging, and unpredictable. Looking back, these are some of my favourite memories of working with him.

Shalin is the reason that, two weeks in at Spa Ceylon Marketing HQ, I had to stand up and read my writing out loud in front of twenty or more people, mostly GenZs! I was nervous and embarrassed at the time, but it taught me confidence and helped me find my voice.

I also remember the day he remarked rather loudly, that my writing sounded like "a certain opposition politician." I glared at him for the comparison, but it definitely made me a better writer.

It didn't take long for me to realise that Shalin's attention to detail is on another level. It can amaze you, impress you, and drive you up the wall, all within a few hours! But somehow, the outcome is always worth it.

Shalin is also a feminist who genuinely walks the talk. His passion and determination have helped raise millions of rupees for meaningful social initiatives, and I've been proud to both witness, and be part of that journey.

In 2025, when I faced some health challenges and seriously considered calling it quits, Shalin didn't let the conversation end there. Instead, he came up with several flexible working options that allowed me to continue contributing while taking care of myself. That support meant a great deal.

On a lighter note, if you travel overseas and return empty-handed, there's a good chance Shalin will remind you, multiple times in multiple ways, that chocolate was expected. True story!

And finally, I can confirm - with video evidence - that while Shalin's creative and artistic talents are undeniable, they do not necessarily extend to singing. To be fair, many of those performances tend to take place in particularly "high spirits."

Shalin, if you are reading this, here's a toast to a fabulous life filled with days of creative chaos ahead of you!

Yours truly,

Dilrukshi Fernando





Lessons That Last a Lifetime

One thing Shalin always used to say that really stuck with me was that you become what you think, and you become like the people you spend the most time with. Back then it just felt like one of those casual life conversations, but it's something I've carried with me ever since. It's made me much more conscious about keeping a positive mindset and being intentional about the people I surround myself with. The older I get, the more I realise how true it actually is.

Another thing he taught all of us probably, was to always think about how you make people feel. That's probably one of the biggest lessons I've taken from him and one I still use in my everyday life. People forget money, meetings, campaigns, and deadlines, but they remember how you treated them at the end of the day.

Oh and career wise, I've got a lot to thank him for. I'm a paid media specialist today because Shalin saw potential in me before I did. He kept pushing me into bigger opportunities, trusted me with them, and honestly changed my career path in a big way.

I'm not too sure if this message is too long, but anyone who knows Shalin knows he's always up for a good time. Team outings, parties, random celebrations... he was always there making things fun. One of my favourite things about working with him was that work never felt overly serious *all the time*. He knew how to push people to do great work but also knew how to laugh, have fun, and bring people together.

And no matter where I bumped into him, he was always the same person, smiling with a hug, asking how things are going and always asking if there was anything he could do to help .

Happiest Birthday to You Shalin! Thanks for the lessons, the opportunities, the laughs, and for being exactly the same genuine person every time I've met you.

Maadhi

Always Thinking Bigger

One thing I always appreciated about Shalin was that he never made work feel small.

Even when we were working on the day-to-day stuff, he had a way of making us think bigger, not just about the task in front of us, but about where we were headed as people and professionals...

When I think back to that time, I don't remember specific campaigns or deadlines as much as I remember the conversations we had. The brutal feedback, the questions that forced me to think differently, and the moments where he trusted me with more responsibility than I thought I was ready for.

I don't think I ever properly said this out loud, but a lot of the confidence I have today was built during those years. Not because someone constantly praised me, but because someone believed I could do more than I thought I could.

One lesson that stayed with me is that growth rarely comes from staying comfortable. Whether it was a new challenge, a difficult conversation, or being pushed to take ownership of something bigger, those moments ended up shaping me far more than the easy ones.

Even months later, I still find myself applying things I learned during that time, sometimes without even realizing where they came from.

It's funny how some people become part of your life story without intending to. They leave fingerprints on the way you think, work and show up every day.

For me, Shalin is one of those people!

Happy Birthday, Shalin.

Thank you for being part of my growth journey.

> "
>
> IT'S FUNNY HOW SOME PEOPLE BECOME PART OF YOUR LIFE STORY WITHOUT INTENDING TO.



Vidu



The Gift of Belief

Hey Shalin,
It's me, Thenu.
I'll never forget the day I was completely overwhelmed with work trying to figure out a video concept. I was stressed, tearing up, and honestly feeling like I wasn't good enough.

Then you called me into your room and my first thought was,,
"Well... this is it, I'm getting fired."

Instead, you gave me a hug and told me it was okay. You told me that everyone gets overwhelmed sometimes, that I was doing well, and that there was never any doubt about that. You told me to take a break and that we'd figure it out together.

I don't know if you realize how much that moment meant to me, but I still carry it with me today. Not many people, especially not many CEOs, would stop what they're doing to make sure someone is okay.

Something else I've always appreciated about you is that you've taught me something new almost every day, whether you meant to or not. Through conversations, random bits of advice, watching how you handle challenges, and simply seeing the way you think, I've learned so much.
Even today, I still use lessons I learned from you. Long after leaving the office, those lessons stayed.

You were never just my boss. You were someone who believed in me when I needed it most and someone who pushed me to grow.

I think that's your real gift. People may forget meetings, projects, or deadlines, but they never forget how you made them feel.

Happy Birthday, Shalin.

Thank you for being one of those
people I'll always be grateful I met.

Thenu



Mr. Jam Jam: Bringing The Fun to Work

I would say the perfect nickname for Shalin would definitely be Mr. Jam Jam. Beyond all the professional encounters I've had with him, I've always loved his Mr. Jam Jam personality. From what I've seen, he's someone who would go to any extent to make sure everyone is having a good time and enjoying themselves.

He has a way of bringing fun into the workplace and making even the busiest days feel lighter.

One memory I'll always cherish is when a good vibe song started playing, and Shalin would immediately ask, "Where is Milhan? Get him to dance!"

Those moments meant a lot to me because they were the little things that made work feel special. It wasn't just about getting the job done, it was about enjoying the journey and creating memories along the way.

Wishing you a very Happy Birthday, Shalin! May your days be filled with laughter, and of course, plenty of Jam Jam moments.

Milhan



The Funniest Dressed Guy

Day one at Spa Ceylon. I see this guy walk in wearing running gear, going from person to person, chatting up all the staff like he owns the place and I'm sitting there thinking who is this funny guy? Did he come to work or just finish a marathon?

So I did what any confused new employee would do, I Googled you and there it was CEO of Spa Ceylon. I genuinely had to read it twice.

The funniest dressed guy in the building was the boss.

And then you found out I was the only guy on the floor surrounded by girls, and without missing a beat you looked me dead in the eye and said, "Bro, you are so lucky & do whatever you want." Zero hesitation.

And honestly? You were right on both counts, lucky to work here, and even luckier to have a boss who keeps it real.

The simplest, funniest and greatest boss I've ever had.

Happy Birthday, Shalin!

Azeem

The Power of Encouragement



Something that i hold close to my heart to this day is the way Shalin would encourage me and basically our whole team, I'd never been in an environment like that before and i truly do credit him for the way that i now run my businesses and my teams alike!

Shalin always pushed me to be better, to learn more, to explore and experiment and i can happily say that i'm constantly doing those things with so much curiosity as opposed to looking at it like a challenge that i might not be able to overcome, there's always a way around things if you look at it from a different perspective and that's a lesson i carry with me everyday both professionally and personally.

Mahika

From Promo Codes to Life Lessons

To the boss who didn't judge me when I wanted to use 'virgin20' as a promo code for our first live sale... and for teaching me the 3 rules of marketing, especially how it always comes down to how you make people feel.

Thank you for everything!!

Happy birthday Shalin!

Wishing you so much good health and happiness in the years to come!

Aveeshya



Lots of Love

Working at Marketing HQ straight out of university was definitely one of the best decisions I ever made. Not only was I fortunate enough to make friends for life, but I also got to learn so much directly from YOU.
It's a blessing I never take for granted and one that I often look back on fondly. Being part of the team when it was still so small definitely came with its share of pressure, but it also meant I learned more than I could have imagined. What made it even better was getting to work so closely with you. It made it easy to joke around, learn, and build a relationship with a boss that I honestly didn't know was possible.

I was trying to think of some of my favourite memories from my time at Spa Ceylon, and there are far too many to count. But one that always comes to mind is the day Mahika and I walked into your office to pitch a campaign idea and somehow ended up spending fifteen minutes telling you our favourite dad jokes instead. The best part was that you laughed at every single one. From that day on, that became our dynamic. We never missed an opportunity to crack a joke, while somehow still managing to pitch and create some really cool things, as one does when working at Spa Ceylon.
I'll also never forget the first time you told us, "It's how you make people feel" that makes the difference. Later, when we moved out of Parkland and saw those words displayed at Rotunda, it felt like a full-circle moment. There are so many memories, and for every single one of them, I am incredibly grateful.

Shalin, I truly hope you have the best day and an even better year ahead. I also hope you know that the lessons I learned at Marketing HQ are ones I carry with me into every room I walk into today. You have, without a doubt, been my favourite boss, and I feel incredibly lucky to have had that experience and to have built the kind of relationship we did.

Happy birthday!! And Cheers to you!! I hope today is as wonderful as the impact you've had on so many of us.

From someone who will always remember how you made her feel when she walked into a room with no experience and had just come straight out of university and you took the time to listen to her anyway,

Lots of love,

Arnila





Thank You For Your Time

Before Spa Ceylon, I was just trying to survive. Security guard. Welder. Carpenter. Whatever paid. I wasn't building anything. I had no direction, no ambition — just the next month's salary and making sure my family was okay. I had stopped thinking beyond that.

Then I joined Spa Ceylon. And slowly, without me even noticing, something started to change.

You taught me marketing, Mr. Shalin. How to read an audience. How to write for people, not at them. What a funnel is and why it matters. Those weekly and monthly conversations where you'd just talk to us — about your own life, about how to wake up on hard mornings, about how to handle conflict, about how to keep going — I carried those home with me every time.

But there's one moment I keep coming back to.

You asked me to do an analytics task. I did it, but it wasn't right. I was expecting to be told to go back and learn, or worse. Instead, you sat down and explained everything — from the ground up. Not just the mistake. The whole picture. How to measure profit. How to think about numbers the right way. You didn't have to do that. You're a founder. That wasn't your job.

But you did it because you wanted me to grow.

I remember thinking — why is this man giving his time to me for this? And that thought alone changed how I saw work, how I saw myself, how I saw what was possible.

You always valued my input. Whenever there was something you thought I could handle, you handed it to me. That kind of trust does something to a person. It makes you want to become who they already think you are.

The way you treat people, the life you've built, the way you move through the world — that is what I'm working toward. I want to travel. I want to build something. I want to wake up with purpose. I didn't know I wanted those things until I watched you.

Happy birthday, Mr. Shalin. You didn't just teach me marketing. You showed me it's okay to want a real life.

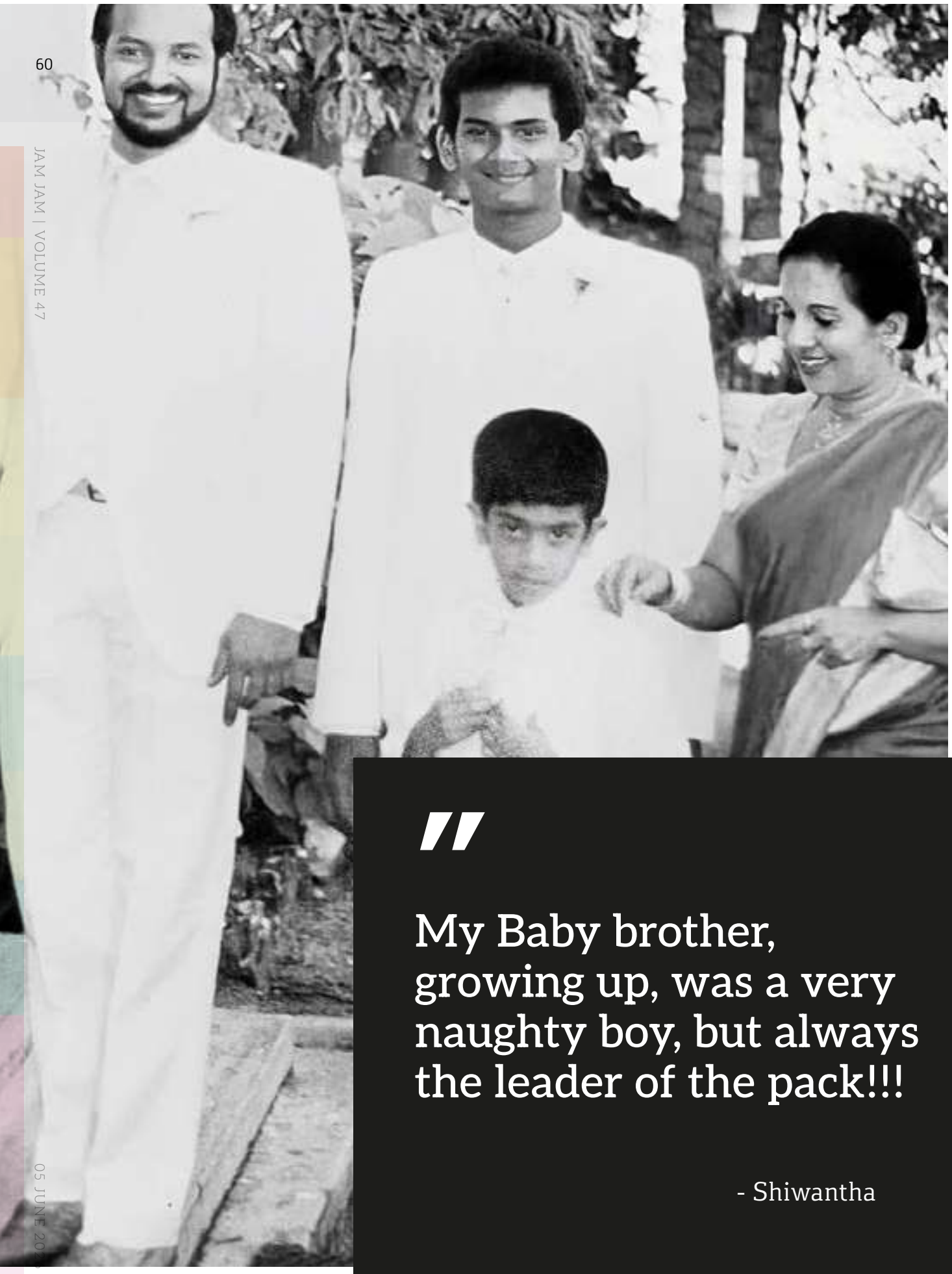
Sumeethan

BEFORE THE WORLD KNEW

From the people who knew you before everyone else did. Before the founder, before the titles, before the world saw what they already knew was there.







"

My Baby brother, growing up, was a very naughty boy, but always the leader of the pack!!!

- Shiwantha



The Gravity Around Him

Growing up with Shalin was
like riding in a tail of a comet

Growing up with Shalin was like riding in a tail of a comet.

There was always an inexorable energy, a momentum that drove everyone forward that had the honour to ride in it's wake.

He was the center point of whatever group he was in - I had the pleasure of being part of that during brief visits to Sri Lanka and then during his university days in Australia. Whether he was regalling me and my sisters with stories as a 10 year old, or teaching me to play cricket at Sinsapa road as at 14 year old or leading us on great night's out in university, he was always at the center of things, weaving the narrative of the day and binding the rest of us around it.

Oh, there was chaos too. No uni assignment was submitted more than 2 minutes before deadline - pages literally grabbed from the printer before a sprint to the lecturers office.
And irony too - he now restores old vehicles as a hobby but his car in Australia was the worst and most unreliable car in the country. A lifetime of work could have been spent in vain on that lemon!

He also had an unhealthy obsession with chilli paste, to be out onto anything and everything whether it was deserved or not. Dining out with him was a challenge as inevitably we'd end up at the place with the spiciest food possible; to which he added chili paste...

But there was love too, which you could feel ebbed naturally from him - whether it was his naturally affection to us in his family or to his wide group of friends for whom he cared so much. There was never anything too small or too large you could ask him, and he would always be there when needed to assist in whatever way he could.

All of these things have helped make him into the man he has become; the leadership skills honed over years of planning everything, the ability to deal with chaos and improvise on the fly, and the values that underpin it all.

Wish him all the very best and no matter what his accomplishments so far, feel the best is yet to come as his comet flies around the world!

- Nish



The Boy Everyone Adored

When he was a baby, he had this really professional nanny in a white saree super-efficient and adored him.

But every time he cried all of us use to run to his room and scold her saying why is the baby crying?

She used to complain to Ammie saying I can't work like this these children are always scolding me when the baby cries.

Babies cry its normal, so Ammie advised us not to scold her. We adored him so much so we couldn't handle it when he cried. I was like his mother sometimes doing stuff for him.

Once when Ammie went overseas, he was quite small maybe around 3 years old the maid was taking him in the pram and since it was going to rain she pushed it fast , he fell and was injured, I slept next to him and felt so sad, but he would still look at us and smile in his cute smile which won the world around him.



Once I washed him and dressed him and he had this tee shirt with a picture of an animal with a thick thread it was supposed to be a tail and I cut it without thinking saying there is a thread hanging out.
He still mentions this to me, you cut my tee shirt ha ha.

He was my page boy when I got married the cutest and most adorable.

When he was a little bigger maybe around 10 years he used to carry my kids and look after them when we all went out together. He was so fond of my 2 kids. They adored him.

He was a scout and once went to a land in piliyandala with his scouting friends on a camp trip next thing they saw some snakes got frightened and came back didn't stay the night.

He used to always play with Shenuka and they used to be up to not good all the time.

When he was a teenager, he was grounded and not allowed to go out, when I came for a visit as he said akkie I want to go out, I will come to your place and go out from there. I told Ammie I will take him to our place for a day since you are not letting him go anywhere let him get a break. She agreed he threw his clothes and shoes over the balcony we put it in the car and he came down in his casual clothes.
That night he went out with his friends and came back to our place late at night, and we dropped him back the next day.
He went home like a good boy ha ha

1st January I came to pick up Ammie to take her to church around 7.30 am 'Shalin was fully dressed I thought he was joining us to church and I said what a good boy he is dressed to go to church, he just fell on the bed and slept with his clothes he had just come home after 31st night out. We had a good laugh.

So many stories to tell about him.
He is the most reliable person to talk to if you need advice, smart, very kind, very creative, good looking and I am his biggest fan.
Love him to the moon and back.

- Shereen





The Art of Seeing Potential

Many know Shalin as someone with an impressive career, specialising in strategic planning & marketing and the successful co-founder of 'SPA CEYLON'. I know him as a wonderful role model to many including my children. He lived with us during his university years in Australia which gave me a front-row seat to observe the qualities that would later make him successful : independent, adaptable, kind & persevering.

A favourite pastime of his was tinkering with cars & he loved driving various vehicles, including the car he drove in Sydney to the classic cars he now restores & preserves. The 'smoky' car he used in Sydney looked more like a racing car (to me it seemed more like an exciting rather than a sensible acquisition) & attracted the attention of traffic police who said to fix it or abandon it ! The car did not last long, but his interest in automobiles certainly did, evolving to more than a short-term interest.

His passion for restoring classic cars reflected a defining quality of his character: an ability to recognise potential where others might not, and a willingness to invest the time & effort to bring out the very best. This same philosophy underpins his approach to building brands or creating value in business.

Whether mentoring young people as a church youth leader or creating meals like a chef or restoring old cars with enthusiasm or being generous (like the day he gave me a Mother's Day cake), he has always approached life with determination and creativity while also enriching the lives of others.

The professional success he has achieved does not surprise me. The qualities that makes him an outstanding leader today - a 'shared' vision for the future , hard work and a remarkable ability to inspire others - were visible long before the world recognized them. People see a successful leader. I see a brother who makes all of us realise that success is measured not only by what we achieve, but by the lives we touch and the lasting improvements we leave along our journey.

- Charmaine

The Boy Who Taught Me Everything

Shalin has always felt more like an older brother than an uncle to me because he's only four years older than I am. We grew up together, as I would go to his house after school and stay there until my mum finished work.

Some of my favourite memories are the simple ones. We used to eat Milo powder from a bowl. We would wait for the Bombai mutai Man to come around and get excited every time we heard him. Shalin was the one who taught me that the wafer-thin plate that comes with it is actually edible. He taught me how to play marbles, card games and board games. He also introduced me to Nayanakatha, a Sri Lankan cookie packed with sugar, and years later he was the first person to introduce me to a McFlurry when I visited Australia at 18.

Our birthdays are only a few days apart, so we often had combined birthday parties growing up. He had a collection of superhero sticker books and naturally I copied him and started collecting them too.

One memory that has always stayed with me happened when i was around 20. My friends, cousins and I were at a match when there was a shooting and some bomb scare and everyone was told to stay where they were. Shalin drove all the way there risking his life to get us and bring us home safely. Looking back it showed how much family meant to him, even then.
We also shared the same tutor. Whenever Shalin didn't feel like having class, he would send me downstairs to tell the tutor he wasn't home while he hid upstairs. The tutor would then cycle all the way back, completely annoyed and only after he left would Shalin casually come downstairs as if nothing had happened.

There were plenty of funny moments too. One day he accidentally sat on a box of drawing pins and ended up with them stuck all over his backside. Another fun fact is that he got stung by a jellyfish when he was about 14 years old. And one habit that has never changed is how long he takes to brush his teeth. To this day, he spends about 20 minutes brushing them, which is somehow





longer than the time he takes to shower!
When he first started going out to parties, he would often come and stay at our house afterwards so his parents wouldn't know how much he had been drinking.
That arrangement came to an end the night he threw up all over my parents' bedroom carpet and bathroom.
After that, sleepovers were no longer an option!

Jokes aside, we have grown up together and I have had the privilege of watching him become the person he is today. What impresses me most is how he sees potential in people before they see it in themselves.
He has an incredible ability to connect with anyone, from any background, and make them feel valued. He inspires people, brings out the best in them and helps them realise what they are capable of.

He is a great leader, a great entertainer, and above all, a great family man. No matter what time of day or night it is, he is always there when someone needs him. He may leave things until the last minute, but somehow he always delivers better than people who have had everything planned for weeks.

I am incredibly proud to have him in my life and proud to call him family.

My wish for him over the next few years is simple - good health, happiness, continued success, and plenty of time with the people he loves most. May he keep inspiring others, growing, and enjoying the amazing life he has worked so hard to build. May God bless him always.

- Shenuka



The Stories We Still Tell

The Day the Ocean Bit Back (Wellawatte Beach, c. 1986)....

I will never forget the day we went for a swim at Wellawatte Beach with Maria and Shalin. The sun was out, the waves were rolling in, and everything was peaceful—until the silence was shattered by Shalin's sudden, piercing screams:

"Ammooo! Aiyoooo! I got bit! I got bit!"

We rushed to him, frantically scanning the water and his skin, but we couldn't see a single thing.

Desperate to help, I grabbed a handful of wet sea sand and started rubbing it vigorously onto his back.

That only made it worse. He screamed even louder:

"Ammmoooo! Redennawa! Redennawa!"

Panicked but determined, we somehow managed to bundle him up and get him back home. As it turned out, the ultimate antidote wasn't medical science it was a big bowl of ice cream. The moment the spoon hit his mouth, the tears miraculously stopped. To this very day, we still laugh about it because nobody actually saw the culprit, but we finally figured it out: Shalin had crossed paths with an invisible jellyfish!

The St. Peter's College Achcharu Ritual

Another unforgettable memory is Shalin coming home from St. Peter's College. He had a daily ritual that always started the exact same way.



The front door would fly open, and he would shout at the top of his lungs: "Maria Akki! Maria Akki! I bought your favourite!" In his hands, he would be holding a precious package of Achcharu, bought from the vendors right at the school gate. The two of them would immediately sit down together on the steps, unfolding the street food wrapped in old newspaper. By today's standards, the food safety level was absolute zero! But back then, it didn't matter at all. Watching them happily devour that spicy, tangy treat and literally licking the "finger juice" delicacy off their hands was pure joy.

It remains one of the sweetest, funniest glimpses of his generous, fun-loving spirit.

- From your loving Aiya

"AMMOOO! AIYOOOO!

I GOT BIT! I GOT BIT!"

THE REACH OF A LIFE

From the people who may have only crossed paths with you once, but somehow carried the moment with them for years afterwards.



You stood by her,
When words were not enough,
When silence spoke louder
Than the world around her.
You held her mind,
Gently... patiently,
Turning fragile thoughts
Into quiet strength.
You touched her past,
And softened every pain,
Painting her memories
With colors of peace again.
For the care you gave,
For the light you shared,
For helping her rise
When she once felt impaired
A thousand thanks is not enough...
Yet from the heart, we say:
Blessings upon you, always.

Jinendra Jagath - Menendi's Dad




SPA CEYLON
AYURVEDA
SPA CEYLON
CINNAMON
ROSE
INTENSIVE
HAND CREAM



To me, he was one of those rare Sri Lankan success stories that made you stop and think,

"Wow, that's actually possible?"

The Unexpected Ripple Effect of Meeting Shalin.

If someone had told me a few years ago that I will meet a successful entrepreneur, and he would accidentally become one of the biggest sources of inspiration in my life, I probably would have rolled my eyes , laughed and said, "Sure... and I'll become a millionaire before 35 while we're at it."

Well, one part of that story is still in progress.
The other part is very real.
Like many people, I first knew Shalin as the face behind Spa Ceylon. To me, he was one of those rare Sri Lankan success stories that made you stop and think, "Wow, that's actually possible?"
Then I met him.....
Now, before anyone reading this magazine gets excited, yeah yeah meeting him was kind of looked like an old Hindi Movie where his bodyguards were probably trying to kill me (kidding...) , and Shenuka was patiently trying to explain why I can't meet him because as usual he is super busy. But sweet little PK came to the rescue at the end.
It all happened on 1st of November 2024 Spa Ceylon Festive Gallery at OGF. I was having mild fever and lot more stressed out due to work pressure. All I wanted was to take a little break and a proof for myself that I can achieve anything if I face my fears. My biggest fear at that time was talking to people. So I decided I should challenge myself to take a picture with the biggest celebrity I know.
I remember feeling nervous. I remember trying to act normal.
But the moment I reached to Shalin and said Hello all my worries melted. I remember us laughing about our names being so similar. Shalin & Shalindi and he gave me few tips to overcome my fears. MISSION COMPLETED!!! .....and the angels started singing in the background. :D
After coming home I took a book and started writing all the things I wanted to achieve in my life but kept ignoring because of my fears. I challenged myself to over come each and everything one after the other.
From that moment, every time I met Shalin, I try to take a picture with him just to remind myself again and again how much a one small act of brave can lead to bigger things in life.
Within a few months I got promoted from Junior Fashion Designer to Senior Fashion Designer and in last year I got promoted as the Head of Design.
Probably when reading this Shalin would say it doesn't have anything to do with him and it all happened because I worked for myself. But if it hadn't been for him, I would never have faced my fears, which later led to changing my life and the lives of others through me.
There's one more person I want to thank in this story.
Janet Balasuriya.
Recently, I came across an article that shared how she was 44 years old when she gave birth to Shalin. Reading it made me pause and think about how remarkable life can be. Sometimes a single decision creates a ripple effect that reaches far beyond what anyone could imagine.
As a fan, I can't help but feel grateful that she chose courage over fear and welcomed him into the world. Because if she hadn't, countless people, including me would never have been inspired by the person he grew up to become.
We often celebrate successful people without remembering the mothers who believed in them long before the world did.
So while this birthday tribute is for Shalin, it is also a quiet Thank you to Janet Balasuriya. Thank you for raising a son whose creativity, vision, humor, and determination have inspired so many people. And for that, I will always be grateful.
Happy Birthday Shalin !

From your forever fan Shalindi :)

A Humble Leader Who Listens



Shalin is very humble in person and paid close attention to a simple idea I had as a youngster. Great inspiration

Kevin Denver Joseph



A Presence That Meant So Much

I just wanted to say that his presence at the funeral was appreciated, and to thank him for making her feel seen and felt during her short time on earth. She truly did appreciate it, and so did our entire family.

Menindi's cousin Amani Nilar

A Reel That Made Me Pause

So random, but one day while i was scrolling i came across one of his reel about hiring interns and for whatever reason i finished it all the way (which is so unusual of me)
But as my dream of being a marketer myself i found that reel quite interesting bcz i always thought i have to be good at everything to be a good marketer but he said we have to capture people's emotion and that made me wonder at myself as i was like that someone who hears everyone not heard always .
(Btw i wanted to apply cus he was so good at convincing yet somehow i didnt)

Anyway i dont know what will happen in future but happy birthday to the boss may all the blessings and joys come to him & to everyone... i am rooting for u guys...

Ishini Fernando



For Menindi

I am Buddhika Erandi Jayasinghe. But more than that, I would like to introduce myself as the aunt of a child who loved Shalin dearly, and who was loved dearly by Shalin in return. On a day like today, I feel that I must speak about Shalin. Most people know, the moment his name is mentioned, that Shalin is the founder of the internationally acclaimed. But today, I want to speak about a side of Shalin that many of you may not know—a story about a giant in the eyes of the world, and a fifteen-year-old little girl whom I knew personally.

During the final chapter of her life, as she bravely battled cancer from an electric wheelchair, this young girl discovered a moment of comfort through a Spa Ceylon product. For a little while, it helped her forget her pain and find peaceful sleep. It eased her anxiety and became a source of comfort and healing. Visiting Spa Ceylon soon became something she looked forward to, a small sanctuary amid a difficult journey.

One day, through Menindi's father, Shalin came to know her story. And Shalin made time for this brave little girl. He invited Menindi to join him for a podcast conversation. Kneeling beside her, he offered her the greatest gifts he could give—his time, his attention, his kindness, and his friendship. Until her very last days, Menindi continued to find remarkable emotional comfort through Spa Ceylon products.

More importantly, she found a story worth sharing. She was able to take all of us whom she loved to her favourite Spa Ceylon outlet and show us a place that had brought her happiness during some of her hardest days.



For a child who had no personal connection to him, other than walking into one of his stores, Shalin quietly gave his time, his compassion, and his heart. Through Shalin, Menindi was introduced to a kind-hearted sister named Sanduni, who became a constant source of warmth and companionship, regularly reaching out to her and sharing conversations that brightened her days.

At the end of March, Menindi peacefully completed her journey and left this world behind.

And on that day, Shalin stopped everything. He came to pay his final respects to his little friend.

As he stood beside her, there was a sadness in his eyes that felt as though he had lost someone from his own family. And even then, around Menindi lingered the fragrance she loved most—the scent of Spa Ceylon Jasmine.

Shalin, Menindi loved you very much. She believed in you. She believed that you would continue to create more little miracles that help children like her forget their pain, even if only for a moment.

And so, today, as Menindi's family, we wanted to share a story about Shalin that the world may not know.

A story that fills our hearts with gratitude, admiration, and affection.

On this special day, we want to offer you our blessings. We would also like to pay our respects to your parents, who raised a responsible, compassionate, and deeply caring human being.

You have carried the name of our small island nation beautifully onto the world stage, and for that—and for your extraordinary humanity, we offer our love and respect.

It is difficult for me to say much more than this, Shalin.

So, from the bottom of our hearts, we wish you a truly blessed and wonderful birthday.

Happy Birthday, Shalin.

With love and gratitude, Menindi's family.

A Message That Stayed With Me

Back in 2020 I was going through a rough phase in terms of career and also personal.
Shalin is my sister's in law and i think my sister may have mentioned this to shalin or her mother in law may have (not too sure how the message got through to him). He also knew me for my laugh as i have met him for certain family gatherings.
And he sent me a message:
"You are too much of a happy spirit to be down about what life throws at you! Keep laughing that happy laugh"
Even though he didn't know it at that time, it really helped me boost my confidence and also to keep moving forward.

Anonymous

MEMORY ROLL

The people, places and moments that somehow always ended up worth remembering.



















For Shalin, work was never meant to be just work.

CREATIVE. CHAOTIC. MEMORABLE.

the **JAM** was the part that reminded us why we were doing it in the first place.

Not because we had to.

Because we genuinely loved being here together.

HQ MKTG


MD
THIS
MY
AM